the third dose for vulnerable groups as the mainstay of India's vaccination strategy, saying it has limited additional value. Overcoming vaccine hesitancy and ensuring people take the first and second vaccine shots should remain the driving force, they believe. Many countries like the US, UK and Germany are offering booster doses, even permitting mixing of vaccines to top-up anti-bodies, for extra protection.

"Running an effective vaccination programme requires adopting a holistic approach," says Mishra. "If given a choice, I would first vaccinate all individuals on the planet with two doses and only then think of the third dose. That would be a bigger assault on the virus. It would reduce the infection and we would have to tackle fewer new variants and their spread."

Policymakers too are reluctant to experiment with the cocktail strategy owing to the risks involved despite health specialists pushing for it. Hence the government's attempt to stick to its original target of 10 million vaccinations a day despite distribution and vaccination constraints, and to cover all adults and those in the 15-18 age group before the end of summer this year.

OMINOUS OMICRON

What is most worrying about Omicron is its infectivity. Many do not even get to know whether they are infected or not, especially as the virus mimics flu symptoms. The younger age group (3-15) are reckoned as carriers, contracting the infection without showing symptoms and warding off the illness with their stronger immunity. Studies on which vaccines best suit them are yet to be done. With milder symptoms, many do not even get tested. This gives the virus more opportunity to change and emerge in new avatars, taxing healthcare systems and introducing a fresh loop in the pandemic. Masks thus remain the most effective protection against its spread. "Omicron is doubling in barely two days," says Dr Jayaprakash Muliyil, chairman of the Scientific Advisory Committee, National Institute of Epidemiology. "It is faster and, in that sense, superior to Delta. It also shows scant respect for previous infection or vaccination. All that is available is based on the Wuhan virus. So a multiple booster against Omicron will not work."

Studies so far show that this variant does not affect the lungs like its predecessors and is confined mainly to the upper respiratory tract. The pathogenicity is lower and the virulence slower. Studies from South Africa show that it is highly immunogenic and also has cross-reactivity for the previous infection. It is an accomplished immunogen. It produces immunity against itself and the speed with which it went up and came down in South Africa suggests it may not be as dangerous as Delta. "If we do not change our mindset from that of the dreaded corona to a benign cold, it will be a greater challenge and as a population we will not be able to face it," says Muliyil, emphasising that those being hospitalised are largely the previously unvaccinated. Moreover, virus positivity is not the way to treat cases anymore. He suggests thinking afresh in terms of illness, begin treating it and confirming the presence of the

SHOT IN THE ARM

Vaccine coverage is on track and India's two-dose target may be complete by June



18+ POPULATION

1ST DOSE
866,230,600
(1,995,852 in last 24 hours)

2ND DOSE
641,617,038
(3,717,175 in last 24 hours)

15-18 YEARS

1ST DOSE
28,274,847
(1,933,743 in last 24 hours)

PRECAUTION DOSE
1,885,715
(879,470 in last 24 hours)

TOTAL DOSES since Jan. 16, '21
1,538,008,200
(8,526,240 in last 24 hours)

(As on Jan. 12, '22 at 7 AM) Source: MoHFW

"IF WE DO NOT CHANGE OUR MINDSET FROM THAT OF THE DREADED CORONA TO A BENIGN COLD, IT WILL BE A GREATER CHALLENGE. AS A POPULATION, WE WILL NOT BE ABLE TO FACE IT"

DR JAYAPRAKASH MULIYIL
Chairman, Scientific Advisory Committee, National Institute of Epidemiology

